

INDIAN TELECOM OPERATOR STRATEGY & MARKET INTELLIGENCE

Why subscriber trajectories differ, how operators compete for customers, and what to watch through 2027

1.288B

Jul 2026 national wireless subscribers

+107.00M

Airtel endpoint subscriber change

38.91%

Top 5 LSA share in Jul 2026

Research scope

Historical lens: TRAI monthly wireless subscriber data, January 2024 to July 2026, across 22 Licensed Service Areas (LSAs). Strategy lens: operator disclosures, customer offers, network investment and recent industry/regulatory developments. Forward lens: a 2027 watchlist, not a prediction.

Project repository: github.com/thousifulla-dev/trai-telecom-market-intelligence

This report is designed as a portfolio market-intelligence supplement to the accompanying Power BI dashboard.

Contents

Section	Topic	Page
01	Executive summary	3
02	Historical market evidence	4
03	Bharti Airtel - premiumisation and integrated customer value	5
04	Reliance Jio - scale, 5G and ecosystem bundling	6
05	Vodafone Idea - network recovery and turnaround	7
06	BSNL - value positioning and network modernisation	8
07	Customer acquisition and retention playbook	9
08	Major 2026 developments	10
09	2027 watchlist	11
10	Methodology and December 2025 reporting revision	12
11	Sources and research notes	13

How to read this report

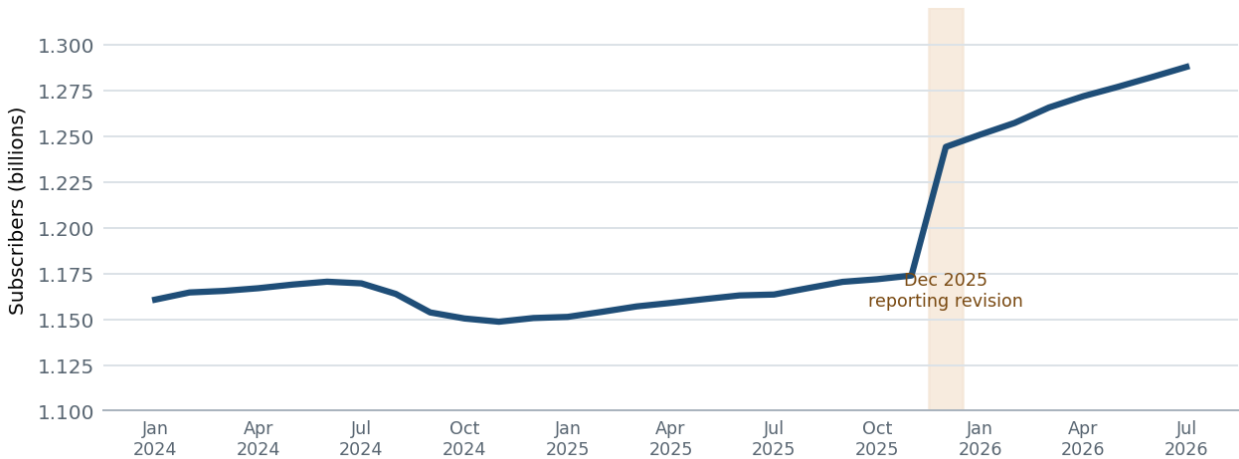
Observed result: drawn directly from the completed TRAI dataset and Power BI analysis. Operator strategy: based on company disclosures, product terms and current offer pages. Industry context: dated events and reputable reporting that may coincide with observed movements. Forward watchlist: variables to monitor; no outcome forecast is presented.

Point-in-time note: Current offers and terms change. Offer details in this report are snapshots checked in September 2026.

AT A GLANCE

01. Executive Summary

The Power BI project tracks India wireless subscribers across 22 LSAs from January 2024 through July 2026. The national subscriber base rose from 1.161B to 1.288B over the period, while operator trajectories diverged materially. The complementary research in this report adds current strategic context - not causal proof - around those patterns.



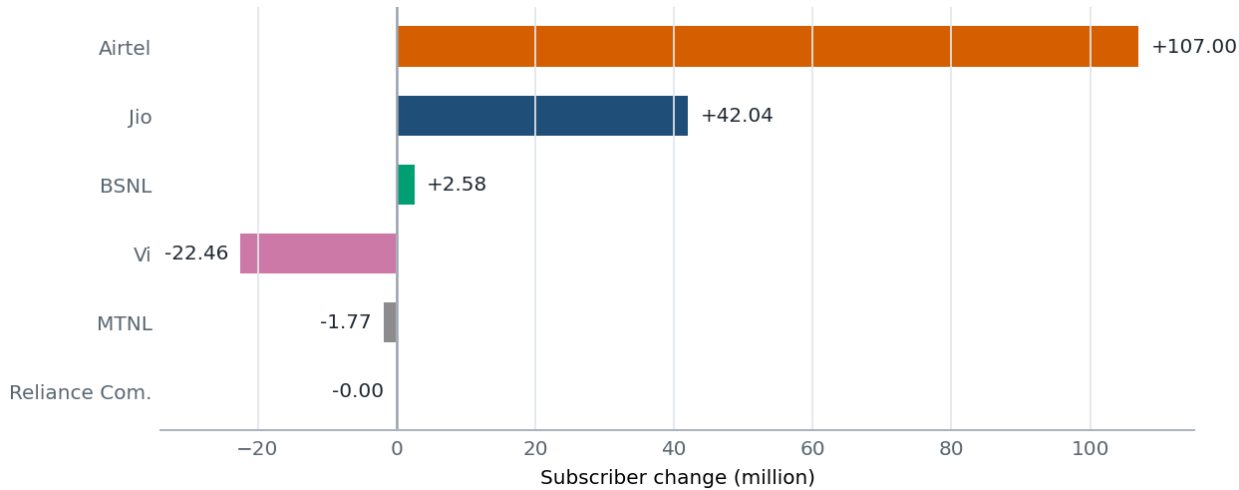
Reading the trend: subscriber growth was positive through the first half of 2024, contracted from July to November 2024, then recovered during 2025 and strengthened through the first seven months of 2026. The December 2025 step-up is a reporting-baseline effect and is treated separately in the methodology section.

Operator lens	Airtel recorded the largest endpoint subscriber increase (+107.00M) and +5.05 pp share change. Jio added +42.04M and held 39.29% share in Jul 2026. Vi declined by 22.46M.
Geographic lens	The five largest LSAs accounted for 38.91% of the Jul 2026 national base. Market-share structures vary sharply by LSA, so national averages can hide regional differences.
Strategy lens	Operators increasingly combine connectivity with 5G, broadband/FWA, premium plans, OTT, family accounts, AI and cloud benefits. These are contextual factors, not measured causes in the TRAI dataset.

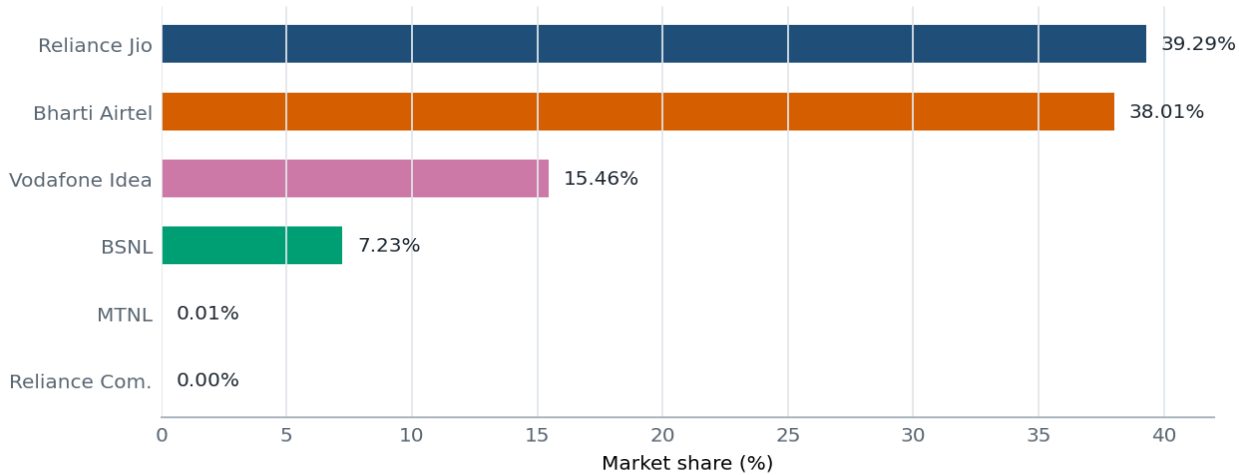
WHAT THE TRAI DATA SHOWS

02. Historical Market Evidence

The most useful analytical distinction is between subscriber count, month-on-month movement, market share, and share change in percentage points. Looking at these together avoids over-reading any single metric.



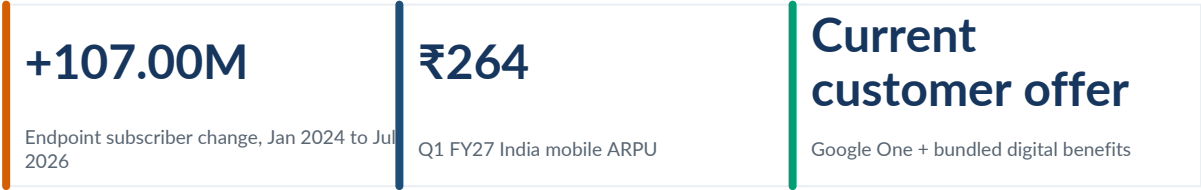
Operator	Jan 2024	Jul 2026	Endpoint change	Share change
Bharti Airtel	382.48M	489.49M	+107.00M	+5.05 pp
Reliance Jio	463.99M	506.03M	+42.04M	-0.68 pp
BSNL	90.59M	93.18M	+2.58M	-0.57 pp
Vodafone Idea	221.53M	199.06M	-22.46M	-3.63 pp
MTNL	1.93M	0.16M	-1.77M	-0.15 pp
Reliance Com.	1,977	119	-1,858	~0.00 pp



July 2026 national shares: Jio 39.29%, Airtel 38.01%, Vi 15.46%, BSNL 7.23%; MTNL and Reliance Com. are immaterial at national share scale.

PREMIUMISATION AND INTEGRATED CUSTOMER VALUE

03. Bharti Airtel



Documented strategy & current context

- Airtel explicitly describes its mobile strategy around portfolio premiumisation, quality-customer acquisition and customer experience.
- Its FY2024-25 report describes continued 5G expansion, rural penetration and digital capabilities; smartphone-data customers reached 276.8M by Mar 2025.
- FY2024-25 network investments included 97 MHz of new spectrum and 44,390 route-km of optical fibre, alongside additional towers and mobile broadband base stations.
- Converged propositions include Airtel Black and Family Plans, bringing mobile, Wi-Fi, OTT, IPTV and DTH into broader account relationships.

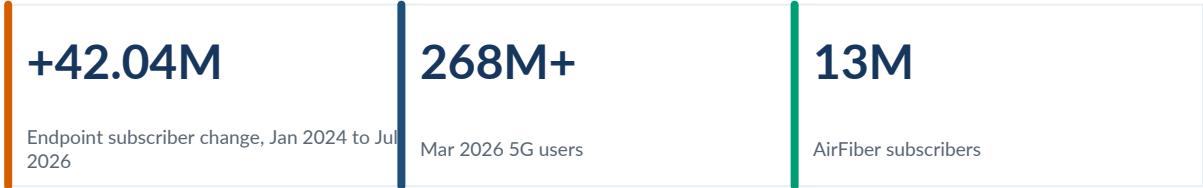
Customer acquisition / retention mechanisms

Mechanism	Documented example	Analytical reading
Premiumisation	Move users toward higher-value smartphone / postpaid relationships.	Higher customer value and ARPU focus.
Family plans	Family plans consolidate multiple connections and benefits under one account.	Deepens household relationship.
OTT / digital bundles	Selected plans include entertainment and digital benefits.	Increases perceived value beyond connectivity.
Cloud benefit	Eligible postpaid / Wi-Fi users can receive six months of Google One; terms tie eligibility to Airtel status.	Adds utility and a continuing service relationship.

Current signal: Airtel reported premiumisation, subscriber upgrades and network investment as strategic levers. Current terms also show benefits such as Google One attached to eligible Airtel relationships. Sources: [2]-[4], plus dated results context from [15].

SCALE, 5G AND ECOSYSTEM BUNDLING

04. Reliance Jio



Documented strategy & current context

- Jio reported a total subscriber base above 524M by Mar 2026, including 268M True5G customers; 5G accounted for about 55% of wireless traffic.
- Jio also reported 27.1M fixed-broadband subscribers and about 13M AirFiber subscribers by Mar 2026.
- The company describes digital services growth across connectivity, entertainment, cloud and AI, broadening the relationship beyond the mobile SIM.
- The ecosystem model can combine mobile, home broadband and digital services in a single customer relationship.

Customer acquisition / retention mechanisms

Mechanism	Documented example	Analytical reading
AI benefit	Eligible Jio users on qualifying 5G plans can receive up to 18 months of Google AI Pro at no additional charge.	High-value benefit tied to maintaining the eligible plan.
OTT / JioHotstar	JioHotstar has been bundled with eligible plans in limited-time offers; the cited 2026 terms page is now marked closed to new subscriptions.	Adds entertainment value to eligible recharge relationships.
Cloud / digital services	Jio promotes cloud and other digital services alongside connectivity.	Extends engagement beyond connectivity.
5G + broadband	Large-scale 5G rollout plus AirFiber/fixed broadband expansion.	Builds a mobile + home connectivity ecosystem.

Current signal: Jio is pursuing ecosystem depth alongside mobile scale. Its current Google AI Pro offer is an explicit example of a digital benefit tied to an eligible Jio relationship. Sources: [5]-[7].

NETWORK RECOVERY AND TURNAROUND

05. Vodafone Idea



Documented strategy & current context

- Vi experienced a prolonged period of subscriber pressure; external industry analysis linked earlier weakness to constrained network investment and delayed 5G rollout relative with peers.
- Vi launched 5G in March 2025 and continued expanding 4G coverage and capacity.
- In Q4 FY26, Vi reported a customer base of 192.8M and said monthly subscriber additions turned positive from February 2026.
- FY26 capex was ₹8,742 crore; 5G was launched in 83 cities and 4G coverage expanded to 86%+ of the population.

Customer acquisition / retention mechanisms

Mechanism	Documented example	Analytical reading
Network recovery	4G capacity/coverage expansion and 5G rollout.	Improve customer experience and reduce network-driven churn risk.
OTT aggregation	Vi Movies & TV offers multiple OTT services, depending on plan, including JioHotstar, Sony LIV and ZEE5.	Differentiate on entertainment value.
Longer-validity value	Selected prepaid plans package OTT access for 56 days, 84 days, six months or one year.	Reduce recharge friction and support plan stickiness.
Funding + capex	FY26 network capex and promoter/funding actions support the rollout programme.	Enable network execution and turnaround investment.

Current signal: Vi's own Q4 FY26 release reported subscriber additions turning positive from February 2026 while network investment accelerated. These are signs of near-term improvement within a longer historical decline. Sources: [7], [13].

VALUE POSITIONING AND GOVERNMENT-BACKED NETWORK MODERNISATION

06. BSNL



Documented strategy & current context

- The Government has approved three BSNL revival packages totalling approximately ₹3.22 lakh crore, covering capital infusion, debt restructuring, rural telephony support and 4G/5G spectrum.
- By early 2026, BSNL had installed more than 97,000 indigenous 4G sites, with more than 95,000 on-air according to government reporting.
- In August 2026, BSNL announced a Re.1 Freedom 2.0 offer for new customers, plus fibre and entertainment initiatives.
- BSNL also uses long-validity/value pricing, broadband and OTT access as part of its customer proposition.

Customer acquisition / retention mechanisms

Mechanism	Documented example	Analytical reading
Value pricing	Low-cost and long-validity propositions.	Compete on affordability and predictable spend.
Network modernisation	Large-scale indigenous 4G rollout with 5G upgrade path.	Improve coverage and network capability.
Broadband + OTT	Fibre Freedom and entertainment offers combine home connectivity with content.	Expand beyond mobile into home services.
Price-sensitive switching signal	After the July 2024 private-sector tariff increases, TRAI/industry analysis showed BSNL gained subscribers while the major private operators lost subscribers in the following month.	Illustrates how price positioning can coincide with subscriber movement in specific periods.

Current signal: BSNL is on a different operating path from the private operators because its network modernisation is closely tied to public policy and government-backed revival support. Sources: [9], [10].

HOW THE OFFER LANDSCAPE IS CHANGING

07. Customer Acquisition & Retention Playbook

Across the market, the customer proposition increasingly extends beyond a SIM and a data allowance. The exact mix differs by operator and plan, but the common levers are price/value, network experience, premiumisation, entertainment, AI/cloud, family relationships and broadband.

Lever	How it works	Examples in 2026 research
Price / value	Low entry prices, long validity or plan bundles attract price-sensitive users.	BSNL value offers; industry tariff changes.
Network quality	Coverage, capacity, 4G/5G rollout and reliability shape perceived service value.	Airtel spectrum/fibre; Jio 5G; Vi 4G/5G; BSNL 4G.
Premiumisation	Move customers toward smartphone, postpaid and higher-value plans.	Airtel explicitly highlights premiumisation.
OTT / entertainment	Bundle streaming, TV and sports access into telecom plans.	Airtel, Jio and Vi offers.
AI / cloud	Add digital tools that create continuing utility.	Jio Google AI Pro; Airtel Google One.
Family accounts	Place multiple connections under one account relationship.	Airtel family postpaid plans.
Broadband / FWA	Extend the relationship from mobile into the home.	Jio AirFiber; Airtel Homes/FWA; BSNL fibre.

A useful interpretation: the more services a customer uses from one operator, the broader the relationship becomes. That may improve perceived value or switching friction, but the effect is not measured directly in the TRAI subscriber dataset.

This commercial logic is best treated as a framework for interpreting current offers. It should not be presented as evidence that a specific bundle caused a historical subscriber gain.

EVENTS RELEVANT TO THE DASHBOARD

08. Major 2026 Developments

Development	What changed	Analytical relevance	Ref
TRAI monthly data	TRAI published July 2026 telecom subscription data on 28 Aug 2026; this is the latest month in the Power BI dataset.	The dashboard therefore has a clear historical cut-off.	[1]
Voice/SMS-only tariff regulation	TRAI released the Telecom Consumers Protection (13th Amendment) Regulations, 2026 on 22 Sep 2026. The amendment requires providers to offer voice-and-SMS-only Special Tariff Vouchers for specified validity bands.	Plan design and consumer segmentation may adjust around the new rules.	[8]
Jio Platforms IPO	India's markets regulator approved the proposed \$3.8B Jio Platforms IPO in Aug 2026, according to Reuters.	Increases visibility around Jio Platforms as a standalone digital-services business.	[11]
2026 tariff expectations	A July 2026 Centrum research note reported an expectation of another 12-15% tariff hike over the next three to four months. This is an analyst expectation, not an announced industry-wide action.	Useful as a watch item for ARPU, churn and plan migration.	[12]
Vi network turn	Vi reported subscriber additions turning positive from Feb 2026, alongside FY26 capex of ₹8,742 crore and 5G in 83 cities.	A key indicator to monitor against the historical subscriber decline.	[7]
BSNL network push	Government reporting shows large-scale indigenous 4G deployment and ongoing customer-centric offers, including Re.1 Freedom 2.0.	A potential source of changing competitive pressure in price-sensitive segments.	[9]

Interpretation discipline

Recent events should be used to provide context around the historical subscriber patterns, not to rewrite them. The strongest statements are those supported by the combination of dated TRAI data, company disclosures and clearly labelled third-party expectations.

FORWARD WATCHLIST

09. What to Watch Through 2027

This section does not forecast an operator winner. Instead, it identifies variables that can be monitored to understand how the market evolves after July 2026.

Watch item	Why it matters	Questions to monitor
Tariffs	Higher prices can increase ARPU but may also increase churn or SIM consolidation.	Who changes prices? How much? How does subscriber movement respond?
ARPU / customer mix	Subscriber counts alone do not show customer value.	Are operators adding users, upgrading users, or both?
5G monetisation	Network investment needs to translate into usage and value.	Is 5G supporting ARPU, premium plans, enterprise revenue or higher usage?
Network execution	Coverage and quality remain central to customer experience.	Does Vi sustain rollout? Does BSNL's 4G expansion translate into usage?
Broadband / FWA	Home connectivity broadens the relationship beyond mobile.	How quickly do AirFiber, FWA and fibre additions continue?
OTT / AI / cloud	Digital bundles can differentiate otherwise similar connectivity plans.	Do benefits remain promotional or move toward recurring monetisation?
Regulation	TRAI rules can change product architecture and pricing structures.	How quickly do operators adapt to new consumer-protection requirements?
Customer behaviour	Price sensitivity, multi-SIM behaviour and switching shape the subscriber mix.	Are users consolidating, switching or retaining multiple SIMs?

Data TRAI subscriber trend	Strategy Company disclosures	Context Regulation + news	Next Variables to monitor
--	--	---	---

Best practice for future updates: keep observed results, company-stated goals, and third-party expectations in separate columns or clearly labelled sections.

DATA QUALITY AND ANALYTICAL DISCIPLINE

10. Methodology & December 2025 Reporting Revision

The underlying Power BI project uses a star-schema style model with Fact_Telecom as the main table and Dim_Date as the calendar dimension. The final analytical dataset contains 4,356 rows and 8 columns at Period × LSA × Operator grain.

Item	Method
Net addition	Current subscribers - previous-month subscribers.
Monthly growth	(Current - Previous) / Previous, calculated only when the previous value is greater than zero.
LSA market share	Operator subscribers / total subscribers within the same LSA and period.
Validation	Duplicate Period × LSA × Operator records: 0; subscriber counts checked for negative values; LSA shares reconciled to ~100%.
Historical operator series	BSNL (VNO's) retained where present historically and not treated as a current July 2026 operator.

December 2025 reporting revision

Original November 2025 total: 1,173,881,921

Revised November baseline used by December report: 1,236,957,678

December 2025 total: 1,244,196,237

December report month-on-month movement: 7,238,559 subscribers.

If the unrevised November figure were compared directly with December, the published series would show an apparent ~70.3M increase. The project includes December 2025 but does not interpret that apparent jump as normal month-on-month subscriber growth. The original November value is preserved for auditability, while the revised baseline is used for December's own month-on-month calculation.

Source handling principle: TRAI published figures are not silently overwritten. Revisions are documented and used only where the reporting context calls for them.

PRIMARY AND SECONDARY SOURCES

11. Sources & Research Notes

Research checked through 23 September 2026. Source hierarchy prioritises TRAI, government, and operator materials; reputable reporting is used for dated market context and analyst expectations.

- [1] TRAI - Telecom Subscription Data reports (includes July 2026).
<https://www.trai.gov.in/release-publication/reports/telecom-subscriptions-reports>
- [2] Bharti Airtel - Integrated Report and Annual Financial Statements 2024-25.
<https://www.airtel.in/airtel-annual-report-2024-25/>
- [3] Airtel - Postpaid Terms and Conditions.
<https://www.airtel.in/mobile/terms-conditions/postpaid>
- [4] Airtel - App FAQ / Google One offer.
<https://www.airtel.in/airtel-app/faq/>
- [15] Reuters - Bharti Airtel results and subscriber-upgrade context, Aug 2026.
<https://www.reuters.com/world/india/indias-bharti-airtel-posts-profit-rise-subscriber-upgrades-2026-08-04/>
- [5] Reliance Industries - FY2025-26 results / Jio Platforms performance.
https://www.ril.com/sites/default/files/2026-04/24042026_Media_Release_RIL_Q4_FY2025-26_Financial_and_Operational_Performance.pdf
- [6] Jio - Google Gemini / Google AI Pro offer.
<https://www.jio.com/google-gemini-offer/>
- [7] Vodafone Idea - Q4 FY26 Media Release.
<https://www.myvi.in/content/dam/microsite/pdfs/Results/FY2025-26/Q4-2026/PR-Q4FY26.pdf>
- [8] TRAI - Telecom Consumers Protection (13th Amendment) Regulations, 2026.
<https://www.trai.gov.in/release-publication/regulations>
- [9] Ministry of Communications / PIB - BSNL customer-centric initiatives, Re.1 Freedom 2.0, 4G expansion.
<https://www.pib.gov.in/PressReleasePage.aspx?PRID=2299484=2@=48>
- [10] Ministry of Communications / PIB - BSNL revival packages and 4G roadmap.
<https://www.pib.gov.in/PressReleasePage.aspx?PRID=2238369=2@=48>
- [11] Reuters - Jio Platforms IPO approval, 28 Aug 2026.
<https://www.reuters.com/world/india/indias-markets-regulator-approves-jio-platforms-38-billion-ipo-2026-08-28/>
- [12] Moneycontrol - Centrum research note reporting an expected 12-15% telecom tariff increase, 6 Jul 2026.
<https://www.moneycontrol.com/news/business/companies/another-12-15-telecom-tariff-hike-expected-in-next-3-4-months-report-13967359.html>
- [13] Vi Movies & TV - All OTT in One App.
<https://www.myvi.in/vi-movies-and-tv/all-ott-in-one-app>
- [14] Economic Times / ETTelecom - subscriber movements after the July 2024 tariff hikes.
<https://telecom.economictimes.indiatimes.com/news/industry/bsnl-adds-4-1-mn-active-users-in-august-as-recent-tariff-hike-hits-jio-airtel-vodafone-idea-motilal-oswal/114689803>

Research note: Current offers, plan eligibility and operator goals can change. Offer-specific details are therefore point-in-time snapshots checked in September 2026. Company-stated goals and third-party expectations are labelled as such and are not treated as guaranteed outcomes.

Dashboard reference: The historical subscriber analysis and interactive Power BI dashboard are available in the project repository:
github.com/thousifulla-dev/trai-telecom-market-intelligence